

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: WILLIAMS BAPTIST UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL

On-Site Review: April 15-17

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 INSTRUCTION	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PARTNERSHIPS
MEETS	MEETS	MEETS
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	Williams Baptist University
LOCATION	Walnut Ridge, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	The report does not name a degree program. It identifies the coursework reviewed as ED 3053 Emergent Literacy and ED 3233 Reading Instruction K-6, and refers throughout to the Williams Teacher Education Program (WTEP).
PATHWAY	Traditional
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	April 15-17

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF INSTRUCTION

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 9 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Exceeds
Concepts of print instruction	Below
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Meets
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Approaching
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Meets
Fluency instruction	Approaching
Vocabulary instruction	Meets
Text comprehension instruction	Meets
Writing instruction	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined course syllabi, course observations and instructor interviews covering the two literacy courses the report names, ED 3053 Emergent Literacy and ED 3233 Reading Instruction K-6. They rated the overview of the science of reading exceeds, crediting Language Essentials for Teachers of Reading and Spelling (LETRS) by Lexia modules 1 to 6, coverage of the Simple View of Reading, the Four-Part Processing Model, Scarborough's Rope and Ehri's Phases, and candidate analysis of neighboring district materials using EdReports. Oral language instruction, phonics and automatic word recognition, vocabulary instruction and text comprehension instruction met expectations. Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction, fluency instruction and writing instruction were approaching, with reviewers citing limited use of assessment data to plan practice lessons, few opportunities to connect fluency instruction to classroom practice, and inconsistent exposure to writing. Concepts of print instruction was below expectations because the literacy courses lacked coverage of it, and the voluntary Lunch and Learn sessions the program had started were not required of all candidates.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Guarantee that coursework instruction and training consistently give candidates the knowledge, terminology and skills to understand and apply concepts of print and writing, and embed that coverage in the science of reading courses or the other required literacy courses rather than in voluntary sessions • Consistently equip candidates to teach text comprehension by teaching listening comprehension as a precursor and by addressing how the characteristics of a reader can affect text comprehension • Build a phonological awareness practice cycle around student assessment data, including candidates administering the Phonological Awareness Skills Test during field experience, teaching the lesson first to peers and then to target students, with instructor feedback at each stage	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 11 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	Meets
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Exceeds
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Exceeds
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Meets
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Exceeds
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Approaching
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Approaching
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Meets
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Exceeds
Quality of written and oral feedback	Meets
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined placement practices, cooperating teacher selection, the progression of field responsibilities and the quality of feedback, and observed four candidate lessons together with the coaching sessions; all observations were virtual. Four criteria exceeded expectations: selection of cooperating teachers, opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice, the build of responsibilities toward full licensure responsibility, and faculty and supervisor guidance and evaluation. Reviewers noted that the program checks the Arkansas teacher licensure database to confirm cooperating teachers hold the reading proficiency pathway, and that field hours build from five to 15 observation hours through two 32 hour field experiences and a pre-clinical internship to a 15 week clinical internship across two placements. Selection of clinical placement schools, use of HQIM in placements, mentor coaching skill, and written and oral feedback met expectations. Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children, opportunities to work with students who experience reading difficulty, and student engagement and candidate impact on student learning were approaching.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Implement a field experience directly aligned with the literacy courses so every candidate works with multilingual students, students experiencing reading difficulty, and students requiring Tier 1 and Tier 2 evidence-based practices, including providing instruction to the local Marshallese population rather than only observing it • Build on the existing written and oral feedback practices by giving candidates opportunities to practice suggested improvement strategies alongside evaluators, so they gain confidence in those strategies and insight into how teacher actions affect student academic outcomes • Require that the instructional units candidates complete focus on struggling readers, and add a field experience aligned with the LETRS modules and literacy coursework so all candidates deliver Tier 2 instruction	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PARTNERSHIPS

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 7 criteria reviewed	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Meets
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Meets
Quality of monitoring	Meets
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Meets
Quality improvement planning	Meets
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Meets
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Meets
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers examined the program's data sources, internal checkpoints, monitoring systems, improvement planning and district partnerships, and interviewed the department chair, program leaders, candidates, alumni, school principals and superintendents, and faculty members. All seven criteria met expectations. The data reviewed included candidate and partnership school surveys, licensure checklists and written feedback from university supervisors, with Williams Teacher Education Program progression points, student support systems, a support tracking document and a student improvement plan serving as internal control gates. Reviewers found an organized system for monitoring candidate progress toward licensure, the quality of oral and written feedback, and cooperating teacher and supervisor performance, and a strategic improvement plan maintained by an internal team using the Diverse Learner Project, dispositions evaluations, internship evaluation data, novice teacher surveys and employer feedback. Partnerships through the local education cooperative gave candidates access to CKLA and Wit and Wisdom, and memoranda of understanding set mentor teacher criteria and secured internships in two grade bands.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
- Identify trends in candidate performance across semesters in the feedback from cooperating teachers and university supervisors, and analyze those trends alongside exit survey data to inform program change rather than only individual candidate support - Integrate additional data points into the end-of-program survey covering how well coursework prepares candidates to meet the needs of neurodiverse, linguistically diverse, and gifted and talented students, and adjust coursework accordingly - Include a variety of external stakeholders in the review of program data before improvement decisions are made, so that the strategic plan for improvement is informed by perspectives from outside the internal team of the education chair, department head and methods instructors	

Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, Williams Baptist University, April 15-17, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024). Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.